

Foxconn 915PL7AE-8S

Foxconn is a new entrant to the motherboard market in India, and they sent us three boards to test. The 915PL7AE board is based on the Intel 915PL chipset and was taken out of the contest because it was the only board for the Intel platform that did not feature onboard video.

This motherboard has an LGA 775 socket CPU interface. It supports up to 2 GB of DDR 400 MHz memory in dual-channel configuration.

There are four SATA connectors and they are configurable as RAID 0, 1, 0+1 as well as Matrix RAID. Onboard Gigabit LAN is also provided. But there is only one IDE connector.

There are four USB2.0 ports. The onboard audio solution is an 8-channel based on the Realtek chip. There are three PCI slots and a PCIe x1 slot provided for expansion. The layout of this deep-blue coloured board is also quite spacious.

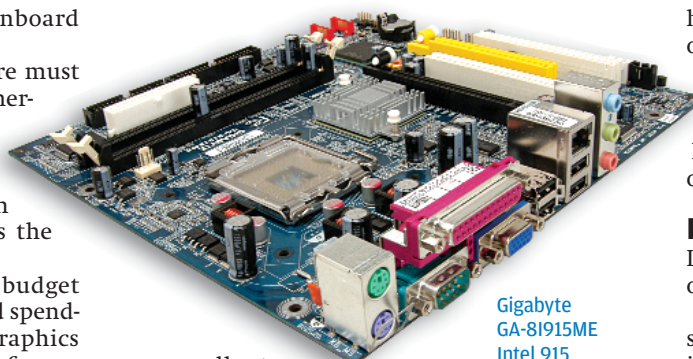
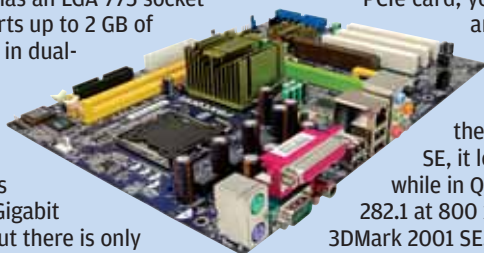
As mentioned before, there is no onboard video. But then there is a PCIe x16 slot. In addition to this, there is a F.G.E. (Fox Graphics Extension) slot that is AGP 8x compliant.

This board is a very good option, especially if you are planning to buy a motherboard as an upgrade to your machine. If you have an AGP card, you can keep using it—there will be no need to invest in a PCIe card. You also have an upgrade option for the future, and if and when you wish to buy a PCIe card, you can just plug it in and get going.

On the performance front, this motherboard leads the pack. In Serious Sam SE, it logged a score of 133.1, while in Quake 3 Arena, it was 282.1 at 800 x 600 at 32-bit colour. In 3DMark 2001 SE, the score was 9101.

This excellent performance must be attributed in part to the nVidia 6200 256 MB PCIe card used in the test. However, you can't discount the fact that the motherboard plays an important role in these scores.

In SiSoft Sandra, too, this motherboard was better than the others. Its PCMark score was 4,945. In the ZDBench Business Winstone, it scored a decent 26.1. You can conclude that the board is very good for office work and gaming alike. At Rs 4,290, this board is a real steal!



Gigabyte
GA-8I915ME
Intel 915

Buy Gold' in the AMD onboard graphics category.

A special mention here must be made of the TUL motherboard. This board may not be an outright shiner, but if you don't want to spend more than Rs 4 to 4.5k, then this is the perfect choice for you.

If you have a budget constraint but don't mind spending a little extra on a graphics card (roughly Rs 4,000 for an nVidia 6200 or the ATi-based X300), then the best solution for you would be the WinFast NF4K8MC. This board has the most surprising performance that we have seen in a while from a board in this category. It gives

you excellent features (almost everything you would find anywhere else, except SLI!), performance and above all, an unbeatable price. So, if you don't mind spending that little bit extra, look no further!

The price, performance and features contribute towards making the WinFast NF4K8MC the Digit 'Best Buy Gold' in the 'AMD Without Onboard Graphics' category.

We would like to make a mention here and say that if you need to choose between two boards, go for one with a 939 socket. Even if the board costs marginally more now, it will more than make up for it later when you want to upgrade to a faster processor.

THE INTEL MOTHERBOARDS

Let us now have a look at what the Intel platform had to offer. Intel motherboards traditionally used to be driven by chipsets manufactured by Intel itself, and occasionally by Via. But today, even entry-level motherboards are based on chipsets manufactured by Intel, Via, SiS and ATi. Like AMD, each chipset manufacturer has tried to cram every possible feature that it could.

Just as we saw in the AMD boards, despite these boards having been labelled as 'entry-level', many of the features that had previously been available only in high-end boards have become standard in these boards. The features we are talking about are SATA, RAID, FireWire, Gigabit LAN, etc. Many of the boards also featured PCIe.

Features

Let's take a look at the features offered by these boards.

A majority of the boards supported the LGA 775 socket interface which, apart from being the latest from Intel, is also a lot safer, as the pins which traditionally used to be on the CPU are now on the socket. The locking mechanism is also sturdy, and the heat-sink fan assembly is very easy to lock onto the moth-

**BEST
SELLER**

The classic 478 Pin solution that comes with Intel® 845/IHC4 chipset.

With an extra AGP slot it allows the user to harness the extra power of the CPU to deliver an excellent video experience.

Supported by AC97 audio codec it can support 6 channel audio systems for a decent Surround Sound Experience.

Designed for Intel® Pentium4® Processor.

